million Indians enrolled overall) by 2019.[123] This widening of the social welfare net is crucially important in a country where most people below the poverty line have hitherto not had access to insurance or social welfare of this kind.

Modi's focus on women reflects a Lohiaite vision. He often quotes a parliamentary speech by the socialist leader Ram Manohar Lohia in the 1960s. 'He said that India's women have two primary problems: one is toilets, the other is water. This means there are no toilets for women and women don't have water to run their households … Lohia ji is gone, many governments have come and gone, leaders have come and gone, but only we have determined that each house will have a toilet as well as water.'[124]

A key part of Modi's gender narrative focuses on changing traditional gender hierarchies in official documentation. The move to give priority to women in house registrations under PM Awaas Yojana is a case in point. Modi argues in his speeches that 'we know that if you ask any woman, even today in our society, the situation is that if you ask in whose name is the house, it will be in the name of the husband or son; whose name is the car, it will be in the name of the husband or son. If you buy even a scooter, it will be in the name of the husband or the son.' To ensure that property can be in the name of women, several rules were changed between 2014 and 2019. For instance, it was no longer necessary for women to provide either their marriage or divorce documents to apply for passports. 'It would be enough for them to provide names of their father or mother … This is our complete commitment towards naari shakti,' said Modi in 2018. 'If women's contributions increase in the country, the country will develop. This is what the dream of New India is about: where women are strong, confident and equal stakeholders in development.'[125]

It is nobody's case that these schemes have no flaws. The Ujjwala scheme, which provided over 80 million free LPG connections between April 2016 and September 2019, could only be availed by women below the poverty line, and these beneficiaries also received direct cash transfers of up to ₹1,600 each.[126] In the initial phases, over 40 per cent of Ujjwala connections were released on single Aadhar cards alone (without the mandatory bank account